Western countries, where there is a comparatively larger presence of Sikhs.'

As the implications of my remarks were rather obvious, no further discussion took place on the subject. It is, however, not known whether Gary's information about the large-scale killing of Sikhs in Delhi following Indira Gandhi's likely assassination was based on an intelligence input by the IB or was an observation by a perceptive officer who had attended the previous day's meeting of senior officers.

'Tomorrow may be too late'

October 21 was a Sunday. I had accompanied my wife and two children to the Lady Hardinge Medical College campus, adjacent to Connaught Place, to meet my wife's eldest sister Dr Paramjeet Panag. On our return journey, as we approached the crossing of Akbar Road and Safdarjung Road, while turning towards Gymkhana Club, I saw two young policemen posted at the corner of 1 Akbar Road, part of the prime minister's official residential complex. Both were armed with Sten guns.

One of them was a 5-foot-8-inch stocky Sikh who appeared to be in his mid-twenties with a closely trimmed beard. Seeing him posted there, I expressed my surprise to my wife as to why armed Sikh police security guards, who were removed from duty at the PM's residence after Operation Blue Star, had been redeployed. 'This is the surest and the easiest way of getting Mrs Gandhi assassinated!' I exclaimed in dismay. From the photographs that appeared in the newspapers later, I identified the young Sikh police constable I had seen as one of the two assassins, Satwant Singh.

On reaching office the next morning, I wrote a small note by hand and addressed it to Gary Saxena. In it I described precisely what I had observed the previous afternoon. In addition to writing that it was the surest and the easiest way of getting the PM killed, I specifically mentioned that all members of the Sikh VVIP security detail posted at the PM's residence must be removed at the earliest, for tomorrow may be too late. Also, a detailed enquiry should be conducted to find out who had recommended or decided their recall,